14.6 Self Respect Movement

In 1929 the first Self-Respect Conference was held in Chengalpattu. In the crucial elections of 1937 the Congress party, led by C. Rajagopalachari, won majority of seats. The Congress party victory was largely because of the decline of Justice Party. The Congress formed the government and Rajaji became the premier of the Madras province.

Soon after assuming power the Congress government introduced Hindi as a compulsory subject in the schools. Periyar launched anti-Hindi agitation. A large number of students have participated in the agitations organized by Periyar.

During this period, the Communist Party (formally launched in 1925) became active in campaigning for socialist programme and organized labour movements. M.Singaravelu, and his associates were impressed by the social reform programmes of the Self Respect Movement, which in turn extended support to the economic programme of the communists, and these two movements agreed to work on a common programme (Erode Plan).



Objectives of Self-Respect League

i) Reforming Dravidian society to make it truly rational.

ii) To teach the truth of ancient Tamil civilization to Dravidians.

iii) Save the Dravidian society from the domination of Aryan culture.

iv) Reforming the Hinduism by eliminating Brahmin influence and superstitious practices.

He wanted to do away with indignities on of Dravidians by creating social awareness among the non-Brahmins in general and the youth In particulars. He advocated Self –Respect marriages, a marriage which was conducted in the absence of Brahmin priesthood, discouraged the people from performing irrational religious ceremonies and not to employ the services of the Brahmins in any of the social events.

Decline of Justice Party

By 1929, the Self-Respect Movement had become a formidable movement in the Madras Presidency. In 1930's the Justice Party began to face decline in the political sphere of the province. There were three major factors responsible for this decline. Firstly, the party lost its support among the Depressed sections of the society and minorities. Secondly the Self-Respect Movement, under Periyar had become more radical. Finally the elitist and pro-British outlook of Justice Party had also contributed significantly for its decline.

14.7 Anti Hindi Agitation

The decline of the Justice Party and Periyar's refusal to enter into electoral politics together with the growing popularity of Mahatma Gandhi, enabled Indian National Congress to win elections in the Madras Presidency in 1937 and Rajagopalachari became the premier.

He introduced total prohibition (ban on liquor) and abolished the Zamindari system, and introduced legislations removing restrictions on temple entry for the depressed classes. Yet his measures leading to closure of many schools and introduction of Hindi as compulsory language in schools provoked the admirers

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